AN IDEAL HUSBAND by Oscar Wilde
(A2+–B1)

INTRODUCTION

Ss read an extract from *An Ideal Husband* by Oscar Wilde in which Mrs Cheveley attempts to blackmail Sir Robert Chiltern with a secret from his past. Ss talk about secrets and find out how much of their personal information is publicly online.

Supplementary Materials

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION Ex 3: internet access OR print out the Answer Key and cut it up into three sections, enough for the whole class to have one section each.

CLIL CONNECTION: internet access for the activity itself. For the lead in, use a video showing someone who seems to have psychic abilities and knows all sorts of private information about members of the public but who is actually just researching the person via social media and the internet. Search for 'Brussels safe internet experiment' to find the video.

WARM UP

Culture notes

Oscar Wilde

Oscar Wilde was born in Dublin, Ireland, in 1854. He studied at Trinity College in Dublin (1871–74), and the University of Oxford (1874–78). Wilde was a very successful and famous writer because of his cleverness with language and his sharp wit and his works are still popular today. He wrote four amusing and very successful plays about London High Society: *Lady Windermere's Fan* (1892), *A Woman of No Importance* (1893), *An Ideal Husband* (1895) and *The Importance of Being Earnest* (1895); he belonged to the part of London society that he wrote about. Oscar Wilde loved art, music, fine clothes and good conversation. He also liked to be different from other people and made many enemies. He was sent to prison for two years and when he came out he was poor and ill. He lived the rest of his life in Paris and died there in 1900.

An Ideal Husband

An Ideal Husband is about a group of rich people in London during the 1890s. Sir Robert Chiltern is the 'ideal husband', who works in the government's foreign office and is happily married to the beautiful Lady Chiltern. When Mrs Cheveley arrives on the scene, however, a secret about Sir Robert's past is revealed and important life-changing decisions must be made.

PREPARATION

THINKING ROUTINE

1

see

Focus Ss on the picture of the two people and ask *What are they doing?* (Someone telling someone else a secret or something shocking or surprising.)

think, wonder

Put Ss in pairs and allow time for them to discuss the questions in *think* and *wonder*. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed, making note of anything useful on the board to draw the class's attention to at the end of the discussion. Get feedback as a class.

ANSWERS:

think

Ss' own answers, but example answers are:

2 It can be good to have secrets as some thoughts and feelings are private. And some secrets can be useful but the temptation can be to use them in the wrong ways to gain power, like in the text.

3 Ss' own answers

4 You shouldn't keep secrets where someone is in danger of being hurt or harmed as a result. In those cases, tell a trusted adult, for example, a teacher or one of your family members.

wonder

Ss' own answers

READING PREVIEW

Focus Ss on the format of the text before they actually read it and explain that this is an extract from a play, not a novel. Ask *What's the difference between a play and a novel?* (A play is written to perform, not to read. There is less or no description, only dialogue. You don't know the characters thoughts or feelings unless those are clear from what they say.) Elicit answers onto the board.

READING EXTRACT LL5.01

Although it is a play, Ss still need time to read silently, or listen to the recording, to understand and absorb any new vocabulary with the help of the glossary. When they have finished reading, remind Ss of the name of the play and ask *Does Sir Robert sound like an 'ideal husband'?* (They may not know 'ideal' so explain it means the perfect example of something. He doesn't sound ideal since he has lied to his wife.)

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COMPREHENSION

2 Focus Ss on the summary, but get them to cover the words in the box at first. Get them to read the summary and ask about any words they don't know, ignoring the gaps for now. Then ask Ss to read the summary again. This time, if they find that any answers pop into their heads for the gap fill, they make a note of them. Then refer them to the words in the box to see if any of the words they noted match the words in the box. Ss try and put the rest of the words into the remaining gaps.

ANSWERS:

1 promise **2** secret **3** past **4** power
5 dishonest **6** success

Teaching tip

With gap fills, encourage Ss to predict what kind of word goes in the gap, e.g. noun, verb, adjective, plural, so they can narrow down the possibilities when they're looking at the words in the box.

Tell Ss that this scene is very early on in the play and it tells us a lot about the characters and their relationships to each other and so, in order to prepare for acting a play, actors need to think about these things. Write the names of the three characters on the board: *Mrs Cheveley, Lady Chiltern, Sir Robert*. Arrange Ss in small groups and tell them to think of one or two adjectives to describe each character and anything they can say about how they feel about each other. Check answers as a class and note main ideas on the board.

POSSIBLE ANSWERS:

Mrs Cheveley: dishonest, dangerous, does not like the Chilterns. Lady Chiltern: angry; protective of her husband and trusts him; a strong person; perhaps condescending because of her social status compared with Mrs Cheveley, who we know she does not like.

Sir Robert: guilty, dishonest in the past but perhaps a reformed character, seems to accept that his secret has been found out as he does not deny it.

Teaching tip

Written as a play, the text is all dialogue, with a few stage directions, so Ss have to infer character and descriptions of people from the way they talk. This format lends itself to reading aloud rather than silent reading and giving Ss time to perform a play is an important part of understanding the reading.

Divide Ss in groups of three again so they can read the script, taking turns to play each role, note that Sir Robert only has one line. If they wish they can get up and move about, following the stage directions. Monitor and help with characterisation, feeling and pronunciation. When they have finished, ask *Which character was the most interesting to play? Why?* (Often the 'baddie' is much more interesting to play even if it's not the character you like best.)

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

3 Ask *What was Sir Robert's secret?* (He sold secret government information to a businessman years ago which made him rich.) *Was his secret a good or bad secret?* (A bad one.) Explain that Sir Robert's job with the government meant keeping secret information, like many jobs. Elicit jobs that mean keeping information secret/ private.

Tell Ss they're going to look at the jobs of army soldiers, doctors and government officials. Divide Ss into pairs and give them time to think of the things the people in those jobs might have to keep secret. In feedback, elicit Ss' ideas as a class but do not confirm answers yet.

Focus Ss on the three secrets in Ex 3. *Ask Which one is the doctor, soldier and government official?* (*Area 51 = soldier; Hippocratic Oath = doctor; Habsburg Napkin = government official*) Divide Ss into groups of three. Allow time for them to choose one of the three things to research, either in class or at home, using the internet.

They should find out more about what each secret is, and why the secret has to be kept. They then explain what they have learned to the other two in their group. Check answers as a class.

Alternative approach

Divide Ss into groups of three to do a jigsaw reading. Hand out the three texts from the Answer Key (see Supplementary materials) so each student in the group has a different text.

Each student reads their text and then, from memory, explains what they have read to the other two in their group. If they have any questions about each others' texts, they should make a note of them to find out more later, either in class or at home, using the internet.

ANSWERS:

1 Area 51: the US government keeps secret what happens at the military base called Area 51. People think they use the area to work on discoveries of UFOs and aliens. It was originally to work on planes and technology during the Cold War. Everyone who works there signs papers to make sure they can't talk about what happens there.

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2 The Hippocratic Oath: kept by doctors about their patients so that patients are protected. Part of it says that patients will not have their private information made public or, for example, given to an insurance company. All doctors swear this oath and they can only give information to another person if the patient might otherwise hurt themselves, or others.

3 The Habsburg Napkin: government officials know how to fold the napkins for the royal table in Austria. It is not written down anywhere and the story says only two people know how to do it at any one time.

SPEAKING

4A/B **Ask *Which of the three secrets would you like to know? Why?* Brief whole class discussion or they can discuss in their groups if they have not already done so. Tell Ss they're now going to think about more personal secrets. Focus Ss on the questions in Ex 4B and allow time for them to discuss in their groups of three.**

ANSWERS:

Ss' own answers. Possibly it's OK to read a diary after the person has died. Without that, we wouldn't have some very famous diaries, e.g. Anne Frank's diary.

CLIL CONNECTION

Information technology

5 **Ask Ss where they can look if they want to find out information about someone they know (online, social media). Ask *How much of your personal information is on the internet?* Show the video (see Supplementary materials) or explain that often people give away more information than they think and that they're going to find out how much of their own information is visible to people they don't know.**

Focus on the questions and ask Ss to log out of all their social media accounts before starting, if they're doing the tasks at home. If they're doing it at school, they are probably not logged in to anything. Allow time for them to work through the questions using internet searches and trying different key words such as their name, address, etc. Encourage them to pretend they are investigating themselves and to make a list of all the things they can find out about themselves. For example, if they use social networking apps people can find out where they have been, things they have bought, where they ate, etc. depending on how much they post. When they have finished, get feedback as a class and ask *What could someone do with this information about you?* (Basically, build a picture of your life but what they then use that information for depends on what is available for them to find.) Ask them if they want to change anything about the information they put online.

Homework ideas

- Ss practise performing the play, learning their own lines at home. You could assign each group a different part of the play by referring to the **Pearson English eReader** and stage a class performance for a longer project. NB There are 12 speaking roles with additional non-speaking roles as party guests.
- Ss imagine they are a film or theatre producer and that they are casting the actors for this scene. They choose famous actors and write about who they would choose and why.
- Ss design a poster advertising the play.
- Ss imagine they are a private detective and write a report about themselves as if they are the subject of their own investigation. They can include key information as well as tracking their movements over a period of time, depending on what they have found out.

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